

TOPIC 2: PRINCIPLES OF DESIGN / ART

1. Meaning of Principles of Design

Principles of design are the guidelines for organising the elements of design into a pleasing and effective composition. They tell us how to arrange the “ingredients” so that the artwork works well.

2. The Principles

- **Balance** – equal distribution of visual weight (symmetrical, asymmetrical or radial).
- **Contrast** – difference between elements (light/dark, large/small, rough/smooth) to create interest.
- **Harmony / Unity** – sense that all parts belong together; the artwork feels complete.
- **Rhythm** – repetition or alternation of elements that creates a sense of movement.
- **Proportion** – relative size of parts to each other and to the whole.
- **Emphasis** – making one part stand out as the focal point.

3. Uses of Principles of Design

Principles guide composition in painting, poster design, crafts, fashion, architecture and photography. Good use of principles makes work clear, attractive and meaningful.

4. Summary

Principles of design – balance, contrast, harmony, rhythm, proportion and emphasis – organise the elements into effective artworks. Practise applying them in your own designs.

End of Topic 2